APRIL 24 / MAY 1, 2023

TIME

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by Nancy Gibbs

time.com

TIME Magazine

[April 24th, 2023]

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How We Chose the 2023 TIME100

Edward Felsenthal is the Executive Chairman and former Editor-in-Chief of TIME.

Sam Jacobs is Editor in Chief at TIME where he leads TIME's global newsroom and its journalism across all platforms. Since joining TIME in 2013, Jacobs has held a variety of senior editorial leadership positions. Previously, he was national political correspondent at Reuters, associate editor at Newsweek and staff reporter for The Daily Beast. His writing has appeared in the Boston Globe and New York Observer.

One of the most inspiring initiatives for us at TIME over the past few years has been convening TIME100 honorees from around the globe. What began nearly two decades ago as an annual list of the world's most influential people has become a community of leaders from across fields, who join together in venues from Singapore and New York City to Dubai and Los Angeles, to spotlight solutions toward a better future. At this year's first gathering of TIME100s, in Davos, Switzerland, the overarching theme was the confluence

of interconnected challenges, from climate and public health to democracy and equality.

That is also the central theme running through the 2023 TIME100 list—starting with the most existential of challenges: climate change. This year's list features a record 16 people defending the environment, including the new leaders of Australia, Colombia, and Brazil, all recently elected on a wave of pro-climate sentiment. Also counted among that group are scientists like Andrea Kritcher, whose experiments brought controlled fusion power closer to reality than ever before; Patagonia founder Yvon Chouinard, who donated his company to the fight; and environmental-justice advocate Catherine Coleman Flowers.

We also include cultural titans like Angela Bassett, whom singer Tina Turner praises for always having "strength, determination, and big, big dreams," and pioneers like Sam Altman, whose company released the generative artificial intelligence platform ChatGPT, advancing what Airbnb founder Brian Chesky calls in this issue "the most powerful tool ever created." Recognized here too are Ozlem Tureci and Ugur Sahin, mRNA-vaccine trailblazers who led the way on COVID-19 jabs and are now turning to cancer vaccines with exciting results. And we may all someday owe a debt to physicist Edward Reynolds, who oversaw a successful mission to collide a small spacecraft with an asteroid in order to knock the latter off course. A passionate group of activists are also on this list, including Shannon Watts, the founder of Moms Demand Action, whose work continues to gain resonance as gun violence remains a tragically daily threat in America's communities.

Central to confronting the world's shared challenges is the pursuit of truth, an endeavor increasingly under attack. We recognize three journalists who have taken great risks in the course of that duty. Elaheh Mohammadi and Niloofar Hamedi, courageous Iranian reporters, have been jailed over their crucial coverage of the protests against the regime. And the work of Evan Gershkovich, a

Wall Street Journal reporter facing bogus espionage charges for reporting on Russia, has galvanized supporters of press freedom around the world. We celebrate Evan's commitment to our profession and join in calling for his immediate release.

See the full 2023 TIME100 list.

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The Historic—and Entirely Predictable—Indictment of Donald Trump

Gibbs, a former writer and editor in chief at TIME, is the director of the Shorenstein Center and the visiting Edward R. Murrow professor at Harvard Kennedy School. She is the co-author, along with Michael Duffy, of two best-selling presidential histories: *The President's Club: Inside the World's Most Exclusive Fraternity* and *The Preacher and the Presidents: Billy Graham in the White House*.

An independently wealthy Republican president is tossed out of office after a single term amid massive economic hardship and fears of political violence. There are rumors he was under surveillance or about to be arrested. Relentless, bitter, appalled at his Democratic successor, he stews in his elegant midtown Manhattan suite, plotting his next move. Except it was not Trump Tower but the Waldorf-Astoria and the ex-president was Herbert Hoover.

But in this case, history neither repeats itself nor rhymes. Hoover not only respected the presidency, he honored it in his post-

presidency. When Franklin Roosevelt announced a bank holiday immediately after his inauguration, Hoover declared he should “receive the whole-hearted support of every citizen.” A decade later, when 100 million people in Europe were at risk of starving, Harry Truman enlisted Hoover’s help managing post-war relief; together they probably saved more lives than any two figures of the 20th– century.

Most ex-presidents enter post Oval life bearing scars and regrets. Some take up painting; some lean into atonement. “We all have sorrows,” as Jimmy Carter told me. Or as the prayer of confession puts it, presidents often leave office haunted by what they have done and what they left undone. The libraries, the foundations and philanthropies, even the memoirs, serve both as explanation and expiation, as their legacies settle and harden.

Buy a print of the Trump Indictment cover here.

Such public service, whether in the name of politics or penitence, has been more the rule than the exception of modern ex-presidents, and so it becomes one more norm that Donald Trump breaks as he enters his long expected season of legal accountability. That he would be the first president ever indicted is both historic and predictable–as is the chance he also will be the second, third and even fourth, in multiple jurisdictions over myriad criminal charges.

The odds were never great that Trump would see his post presidency as a chance to serve the public good, having not seen the presidency that way. He never showed that he felt the weight of the office and its fateful duties; it was more a profit center, a

platform for shakedowns and ego strokes. The post presidency is a platform for, as he put it, “retribution.” Plus, sales.

And this is the ongoing damage he does, the careless splashing of paint stripper on the majesty of the American presidency. His peers were not perfect; but few were vandals. Other presidents have tried to salvage campaigns, but none we know of with hush money to a porn star. Other ex-presidents exalt their faithful supporters–but not when they are serving time for insurrection. Other presidents have turned their stature into a revenue stream, giving speeches at six figures a pop; it’s a safe bet that none thought about merch featuring a mug shot.

Which brings us to the deeper tragedy. For millions of people who’ve believed and supported Trump from the start, defending the rule of law requires defending *him*. Millions of voters are breaking norms too; if his campaign is telling the truth that the money flowed faster the minute Trump was indicted—$4 million in the first 24 hours, a quarter from first time donors they say—then we get what we reward. He has gotten this far by tapping into needs and wants that long pre-date him. The networks running blanket coverage of baggage handlers and motorcades do so in response to perceived demand. They also help create that demand. The

Republican lawmakers who know better yet make him a martyr make cynicism cringe.

As a measure of people's loss of faith in institutions, in courts and judges and prosecutors, in fairness and process and equal justice for all, the entire spectacle is a crime scene. Presidents swear an oath to uphold the laws; former presidents are granted protections and privileges because they served and are in a position to serve in new ways, and in the past presidents have used that opportunity to do tremendous global good. The scandal of Donald Trump's passage through public life rests both in what he has done and what he has left undone–so much power to do good, deployed instead to divide and conquer.

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Michael B. Jordan Worked Through ‘Some Personal Sh-t’ With Creed III

Belinda Luscombe is an editor at large at TIME, where she has covered a wide swath of topics, but specializes in interviews, profiles, and essays. In 2010, she won the Council on Contemporary Families Media Award for her stories on the ways marriage is changing. She is also author of *Marriageology: the Art and Science of Staying Together*.

It’s a big deal when any director’s debut movie sells $100 million worth of tickets in its first week. It’s an even bigger deal when that director is also the star. And it’s a triumvirate of big deals when that normal-sized star transformed plausibly into a heavyweight boxer to play the role. But that’s the position in which Michael B. Jordan, 36, finds himself in the wake of *Creed III*, which is either the third installment of the Creed franchise or the ninth installment of the Rocky franchise, depending on your age.

Despite the many hard yards that being a director-leading man-athlete entails, Jordan, one of *TIME*‘s 100 most influential people of 2023, is raring to get back in the directing ring again. “I got the

bug. I love it. I'm looking forward to the next time sitting behind the camera," says the star. He was sufficiently nervous about his first attempt that he called up such actor-directors as Bradley Cooper, Denzel Washington, and Jon Favreau to get tips on how to multitask, handle the unknown, and say *action* and *cut* when you're in the middle of a scene.

There's a reason Jordan took such control of the future of the Creed storyline. It was personal for him. "I had something to say. I had a unique opportunity to play a character three times over the past nine years, and have a character that was going through similar things that I was personally, and finding ways to work through my own sh-t through a character," he says. "As an actor, you try to find characters that you can pull yourself into, and you can relate to, and you can almost kind of use that as like a therapeutic opportunity. And Adonis Creed was that for me."

In this iteration of the movie, Creed is in an arc of his of life where things are going extraordinarily well. "At this point in his career, I kind of know what somebody like that will be going through, because I'm kind of going through that same sh-t," says Jordan. "It was something that I knew nobody else could tell but me. So it was a perfect fit."

Like Creed, Jordan has fame, respect, and enough money to buy everything he needs and wants and to look after those around him. After his first real paydays, for *The Wire* and *Hardball*, his mom took him to a car lot near where he lived in New Jersey and he bought a BMW330 CI, stick shift. More recently, he bought his mom a house. Like Creed, people expect a lot of him. (He recently was invited to dinner with President Obama and executives from his film production company.) And like Creed, he regularly has to drive by large billboards of himself modeling fancy clothing, or at least, fancy underpants. "It's kind of out of out of body experience," he says of seeing huge images of himself in Calvin

Kleins. “It’s just like, wow, that’s a lot. That’s a lot, being up there.”

Finally, just like Creed, Jordan’s on the receiving end of a lot of people’s opinions about his work. While he appreciates the critical and popular acclaim the film has garnered, he tries to keep his circle of influencers pretty tight. “I don’t think the human brain is really built for millions and millions of opinions,” he says. “Humanity in general, you’re used to your tribe, you know, 20-30 people, that you care about: your family, your friends, and that extended group.” But he acknowledges that social media is tough to ignore. “You have to filter through and listen to people that you don’t know and their opinion shouldn’t really affect you like that, but it does.”

Read More: *Michael B. Jordan Is Redefining What It Means to Be a Movie Star*

Jordan had already leaned into his own rising influence with his 2018 pledge to use inclusion riders, which are clauses in contracts that call for more diversity among the cast and crew, for any film his company produces. But he’s looking for more permanent commitments. “I think you have a lot of corporate America checking boxes to satisfy the people or outcry or a moment,” he says. “And sometimes that energy is lost, as people forget. You get back to business as usual.”

Having been a working actor since his teens, Jordan has had some time to metabolize what it means to be someone people look up to, even though he says influence is not something that he sought. “It’s something that, for me anyway, I had to learn how to accept,” he says. And just as when he worked on Creed, he’s not shying from the heavy lifting. “I think I’ve accepted my role as a leader—and all the weight that comes with that.”

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Bob Iger on Ron DeSantis, Creativity, and the Future of Disney

Belinda Luscombe is an editor at large at TIME, where she has covered a wide swath of topics, but specializes in interviews, profiles, and essays. In 2010, she won the Council on Contemporary Families Media Award for her stories on the ways marriage is changing. She is also author of *Marriageology: the Art and Science of Staying Together*.

Disney's old and then new again CEO Bob Iger was early for his 2023 TIME100 cover shoot on a soundstage at the studio lot, as he pretty much is for all his appointments every day. And he managed the photo session as carefully as he manages Disney's many intellectual properties—from Thor to Mickey—making sure he understood what photographer Paola Kudacki wanted while also ensuring it aligned with his own aims of not looking awkward.

That was perhaps more impressive since Iger, 72, is already in the awkward position of stepping back in to head the company after his handpicked successor, Bob Chapek, lasted fewer than three years. Chapek's dismissal came on the heels of a meeting in which he

could not find the appropriately sober-but-optimistic tone to reveal to shareholders that Disney had lost billions more than expected on its new streaming service. It also came on the heels of a political feud in Florida and internal uproar over redistribution of power within the studio.

On the day of the shoot, Iger was fresh off a recent round of victories. The Disney stock price was up 9% since he took back the CEO reins, after falling 44% in the 12 months prior. He'd effected a round of cuts whose victims included Ike Perlmutter, the executive who sold him Marvel, one of his most valuable purchases, but who had recently become a thorn in his side. And Disney was making headlines for out-maneuvering Florida Governor Ron DeSantis, who had been trying to limit the media giant's power in his state by appointing new officials to a local council that Disney formerly ran, only to find the council had previously divested itself of any power. All of that and it wasn't even 9 a.m.

Iger sat down for an interview about how he is managing this very different phase of Disney's journey, where he gets advice, and if he feels influential.

How surprised are you to find yourself back at the helm of Disney?

Very, very surprised. It's not something I anticipated doing. But I'm certainly happy to be here.

What do you see as your prime responsibility at the company now?

I was brought back for a reason. The company had gone through a very difficult period, exacerbated by a global pandemic. And more

than anything, the company needed stability, needed to establish a set of priorities and focus on them. The only way you end up getting to success is by deciding what the opportunities are, and then organizing your people and your company to go after them.

A lot of media companies are going through similar turbulent, resource reallocation processes as Disney is right now. Do you feel like that you're being watched to see how you handle them?

Yes, I do. There's no such thing as not being watched in this job. And while I'm aware of that, it doesn't have much of an impact on how I lead or behave.

Is there anybody to whom you're looking who's done a similar thing?

The person that I think most of, that I was fortunate enough to have observed very closely, is Steve Jobs. He was brought back to a company that he had founded—very different circumstances. But speaking with him when I did, and reflecting on what his experiences were—I've taken a lot from that. One is when you are brought back, and you agree to come back, you have to do so with unbelievable enthusiasm, and not an ounce of hesitation. And then you have to know very quickly what it is you're expected to accomplish and what it is you can accomplish. And then go at it with incredible resolve, incredible zeal, and incredible energy.

When you were asked, was yes your immediate answer?

It was not something I was contemplating. I had been out for about a year, 11 months. The Chairman of the Board of Disney set up a

call with me. When I told [my wife Willow Bay] about the call, she immediately questioned what it would be about. I think she actually said, ‘They’re probably not going to ask you back.’ And I said, ‘Well, what if they do?’ And she immediately responded, ‘Yes.’ I have such respect for her instinct, that when the call came and I was asked by the chairman of our board to come back, I responded, yes without any hesitation. There are certain things that I felt I needed to stipulate. But it was a quick decision.

How much of the way that you’re navigating these challenges now is instinctual to you and how much of it is experience?

It’s definitely both. I was the CEO of the company for 15 years and the executive chairman for two. I was also [COO] for five years. I’m also well aware that today’s environment is different. Even in the year that I was out, things have shifted. You have to be capable of adapting quickly, which is something you learn leading over time.

One of the tasks in front of you is to save $5.5 billion in Disney’s annual budget. Is there any part of that process that can be creative?

The $5.5 billion was a number that we came up with that we thought was not only achievable, but that was necessary to the bottom line success of the company. While reducing costs is not one’s favorite thing to do, it is a necessary thing to do often, particularly as conditions change. And in many respects, it does force a discipline and a focus, and maybe a sense of urgency, and I think that can result in, I wouldn’t say necessarily creativity as much as a resourcefulness and focus on what’s possible, and what’s necessary.

Your reorganization of the company puts a lot of control back in the hands of creators, which has been your signature management style. What makes you think that creative people are good at figuring out such things as distribution channels and ad sales?

There's nothing I'm more sure about than the decision that we made and the need to tie accountability—and to some extent, a degree of control—over the business side of our business with the creative side of our business. If you are the manager of creativity, then it is absolutely necessary that you have complete accountability for the results of the creativity that you're managing, not just in terms of revenue generation, but in terms of how much you spend on what you create, how much you spend to bring it to market—not just distribution costs, but marketing costs. One of the things that is most important for those managing creativity is a very, very defined, and very, very tangible feedback loop.

You made some news recently by firing several executives, including the guy who sold you Marvel, Ike Perlmutter. Do you handle those personally?

There are times I handle it personally and there are times that I don't. I'd rather not get into details about this one. This was a necessary step in the direction of us creating a more efficient company. There was redundancy specific to the way Marvel was being managed.

So the campaign that Perlmutter championed to get [activist shareholder] Nelson Peltz on the

board didn’t play into the decision at all?

This decision would have been made regardless of that.

One of the biggest decisions you’re facing is the fate of Hulu, whether Disney will buy it out. There’s a deadline approaching. What are the considerations that you’re thinking about as you make that decision?

We own about two thirds of Hulu, and Comcast owns the other piece, and they actually have the right to put their piece to us, in other words, force us to buy them out. If they decide to do that, then we have no choice but to buy them out.

One of the ways that Disney is trying to maximize its resources is to increase the longevity of its franchises. How do you not kill the goose that lays the golden egg?

The answer is really to continue to fuel it with great creativity, particularly storytelling, to not *underinvest*, actually, in those. And to respect the past, but also be completely capable of and willing to be relevant by some degree of modernization; understanding that the world has changed and while certain stories stand the test of time, others don’t. You have to be incredibly adept at being able to read the read the room, so to speak, or the world, in order to maintain brand relevance, character relevance, franchise relevance.

In a period of wanting to shrink expenditures, you’re still talking about ambitious spending on

creativity?

If you look at the reductions that we're making, they're designed to invest the right amount of money in great creativity. The more efficient you are at running a company, the more you can spend on what is the most necessary. In this case, it's quality and creativity.

What are the influences on how you curate Disney's output?

We want to continue to make programs that don't necessarily fit into one of our core brands, but we probably should make less of them. I think actually curation is a good thing, because it probably forces more discipline on us in terms of quality. The more you make, typically, you dilute quality. And we're looking to do the opposite.

So, fewer, bigger things?

Not necessarily bigger. Fewer, better.

Disney and TIME are both 100 year old companies. You've worked for Disney for a long time. Do you see staying with one company for a whole career as an option for people in the future, or is business changing?

I'm now pausing for a moment to realize that I've worked at this company for half of its existence, which is pretty crazy. I was extremely fortunate that I started working at a company and in a business that experienced phenomenal growth and expansion over the course of the five decades that I worked in it. I didn't have to

leave a company or even an industry to get more opportunities. So I think it's not about whether whether a person commits to staying for a long period of time or not, it's whether the company they work for and the business that they're in, provide them with the kind of opportunities they expected for their own for themselves for their lives.

Can you change a company and keep the values?

I actually think that if you study great companies over time and you try to figure out why some companies stand the test of time and others do not, you would quickly conclude that most companies fade away because they've abandoned the core values that created the company in the first place. That, in the interest of staying relevant, they distance themselves from the essence of what they were. There is a way to completely adhere to those same values but to present them to the world to your customers, and to your employees in much more relevant ways.

Speaking of values, I'm interested that ESPN invested $250 million in DraftKings, the sports betting outfit, while Disney decided to take Marvel characters off poker machines. Is gambling something that Disney is interested in investing in?

Not really. ESPN is interested in figuring out a way to enable its consumers, who are watching sports on television or mobile devices or whatever, to participate in some form of sports betting without having to leave the experience completely. It's basically trying to increase engagement.

You don't seem that thrilled about it.

I was probably on the more conservative side about this for a long time. But I've changed because I think the acceptance of sports betting has grown significantly. And my desire is to see that the company continues to serve its consumers well, without us really, I think, distancing ourselves from values, because we're not actually causing the bets to be made. We're just enabling people to link to companies that do that. I don't think it's an issue.

What did you do with your first paycheck?

You have to understand that I started in 1974. My salary was I think, $150 a week, and I got a check every two weeks. I got what would have been a $300 check. My rent in New York City was $300 a month. So one of my checks always paid my rent. I had to live on the other. I have no idea what I did with it, except that I spent it because I had to spend every single cent that I made in order to live.

If you could influence went to one person to do one thing, what would that be?

I would try to influence myself to relax a little bit more.

I cannot let this interview finish without asking you about the situation in Florida. Did you checkmate Ron DeSantis?

Disney World opened just over 50 years ago. It was the vision and the dream of Walt Disney, probably the most ambitious thing he ever did—turning swampland in Central Florida into a business that employs over 75,000 people, that is visited by tens of millions of people every year, that is a major tourist destination in the United States, and for the state of Florida, that creates huge value

for our company and its employees, and for the state of Florida itself. Our sole goal in Florida is to continue creating that value for all those constituencies. All we want is a relationship with the state that enables us to continue to do that. We have the wherewithal and we have the desire to continue to invest there to grow that business so that we can hire more people so that we can increase our attendance, and so that we can basically increase more value for the Walt Disney Company and for the state of Florida. It's that simple.

Usually, you're very much a let's-sit-down-and-get-past-our differences guy, and much less a let's-go-to-the-mattresses guy. Is there no trying to meet with the governor?

I do not view this as a going-to-mattresses situation for us. If the governor of Florida wants to meet with me to discuss all of this, of course, I would be glad to do that. You know, I'm one that typically has respected our elected officials and the responsibility that they have, and there would be no reason why I wouldn't do that.

One of your tasks now is to find a new Disney CEO. How will the search be different?

Well, it's not only one of my tasks; it's the primary priority of the board. They're meeting on a regular basis, defining what qualities we're looking for and what people we might want to consider. Given the events of the last couple of years, it's not only a priority, but will get more time, more attention, more focus than it did before. We've always viewed it as an important decision. But given the fact that I'm not here forever and and we had some difficulties these last couple of years, it's getting more attention than than it has in the past.

Correction, April 13

The original version of this story misstated one of Bob Iger's roles during his tenure at Disney. He was COO for 5 years, not CFO.

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Jennifer Coolidge Has Some Life Advice for You

Belinda Luscombe is an editor at large at TIME, where she has covered a wide swath of topics, but specializes in interviews, profiles, and essays. In 2010, she won the Council on Contemporary Families Media Award for her stories on the ways marriage is changing. She is also author of *Marriageology: the Art and Science of Staying Together*.

On a recent evening the actress Jennifer Coolidge was watching a Harry Styles performance on her phone, and she got to wondering why she was not more like him. “I was thinking how confident he was and I was like, ‘Why didn’t it occur to me to be like that?’” she says. “There’s self love and love of the world and love of other people. And he puts it all on stage. It’s such an attractive thing. No one wants the person that’s like, ‘ahhh, I’m not very good.’”

Not to diminish Mr. Styles’ charms, but it turns out that people actually do want more of Coolidge’s mixture of authenticity,

hilarity, and obliviousness to her own charms. After winning more awards in the last 12 months for her performance as Tanya McQuoid in *The White Lotus* than she garnered nominations for any other role in her entire 30-year career, and giving the kind of frank and unconventional acceptance speeches that go viral, Coolidge, 61, is offering hope to late bloomers everywhere. She's finding new audiences, gathering more than a million fans in just two measly months and five measly videos on TikTok, starring alongside J.Lo in *Shotgun Wedding*, and appearing in e.l.f. Cosmetics' Super Bowl commercial. On top of all that, she's on the 2023 TIME 100.

"I just find it baffling, absolutely baffling, that this is happening. But guess what? I really like it," says Coolidge. "It's like I was like Sleeping Beauty, where I was locked in a box under the bed or something. And now I'm out and it's like, 'Well, I'm sure glad they let me out of that box, because this is way better.'" In one of the surest signs of celebrification, fashion labels are sending her clothes—to her enormous relief. "If I have to come up with the stuff, it's never that great," she says. She wears them to the new places she's invited. "People that you don't even know—cool people that I've always respected are inviting me to cool parties and producers and directors that I've admired, I'm actually meeting with them now."

The newfound success and adulation has caused her to look back on her prior work, to assess if she was doing anything differently. She doesn't think so. "I saw some things recently that I did in my youth, and they weren't bad," she says. "I thought maybe I wasn't good or something. But I wasn't bad." She's particularly proud of her work as the down-on-her-luck beautician Paulette Bonafonté in *Legally Blonde*. Or, at least she admits to being proud of that film, which foresaw, among other things, the #MeToo movement a decade and a half before it broke into the mainstream. "It predicted a lot of things. I'm glad I was part of that," says Coolidge. "Many

of the people who come up to me say the same thing, and that is, ‘I went to law school because of that movie.’”

In her newly influential state, Coolidge says that if she had any advice for younger women it would be that they should focus less on being attractive to a partner and more on finding their own way. “There was just like, a giant chunk of my life that was wasted on trying to get boyfriends who didn’t want me, instead of just, you know, taking care of business and, and working on my own thing,” she says. “I think we have to really take care of ourselves and get our own thing going. And then if a guy comes in, it’s all great. Or if a guy doesn’t come in, it’s all great.”

When she was young, Coolidge used to stand on the dock of the little river near her parent’s house in Norwell, Mass. “Whenever a little plane would fly over, I’d be like, ‘Take me out of here! Get me somewhere really cool!’ But the planes never stopped,” she says. Her father gave her a piece of advice that she didn’t understand at the time. “He used to say this quote to me all the time as a kid: ‘Character is fate.’ As an older person, I’ve realized that’s one of the most accurate things I’ve ever heard,” she says. “Who you are in this lifetime decides your ending and how your life will go.”

It’s possible that the culture may have shifted in Coolidge’s favor, that the era of the incredibly polished and on-message public figure is over, and people can respond to somebody who’s more authentic and messy. If a guy with a stutter can become the president of the United States, why can’t an unguarded scatterbrain become a movie idol? “I think people really just like the honest answer, even if it’s not what you’re supposed to say,” says Coolidge. “Maybe that’s what I’m doing: I’m saying things that you’re not supposed to say.” But lest anyone think she might be tooting her own horn, Coolidge quickly clarifies. “To be honest, sometimes I think it’s just because I’m tired.”

Correction, April 13

The original version of this story misstated the movie that Jennifer Coolidge appears in alongside J. Lo. It is *Shotgun Wedding*, not *Destination Wedding*.

Buy a print of the TIME100 Jennifer Coolidge cover here.

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Salman Rushdie Is Recovering, Reflecting, and Writing About the Attack on His Life

Karl Vick is an editor at large at TIME. He has also served as TIME's Jerusalem bureau chief. He has reported from 60 countries and in 2001 was a finalist for the Pulitzer Prize for Public Service for coverage of the spread of AIDS in Africa.

Salman Rushdie is back at his desk, savoring the acclaim for his most recent work and bending to the next—his account of the attack that nearly killed him last summer on a stage in Chautauqua, N.Y.

“If it’s a book, it’s not going to be a particularly long book,” he tells TIME. “Might be a couple hundred pages, so I’m hoping that I could do it in a year or so. But I’m not beating myself up about it. I’m just getting it right.”

Rushdie, who was stabbed more than 10 times, describes his recovery from the Aug. 12, 2022 attack with the kind of measured care that has kept him in the land of the living. “Slowly does it,” he says. A tinted lens hides his right eye, which no longer sees. “The

knife went quite deep in. The knife went as far as the optic nerve." He also lost the use, for a time, of his left hand, but that's coming back. His longtime therapist has helped with "nightmares, and that sort of thing," he says.

As the young New Jersey man charged with attacking him, Hadi Matar, awaits trial in Chautauqua County Jail, the author gingerly gauges the limits on his own freedom. Rushdie did virtually no publicity for his widely praised new novel, *Victory City*. And he had given only one interview before talking to TIME, which today featured him on the 2023 TIME100 list of the most influential people in the world.

Read More: *Salman Rushdie Has Lived Under the Threat of Violence for Decades*

"I'm happy to be on the list. It means somebody's noticing what I do," he says. "One of the things that I liked about the way in which *Victory City* has been received—it's been wonderfully well received, but I didn't get the sense that the reviews were written out of sympathy. There were serious reviews, which were about the work. And I thought in a way it's good because that book, coming out when it did, slightly changed the subject, that it's not only somebody who is the target of an attack, but also there's a creative artist here. Being included in this eminent list is another way of saying I'm not just somebody who got attacked."

And yet on the day that Rushdie, 75, spoke with me from his New York City home, it was into the camera of the laptop on which he's pecking out what will be something of a sequel to *Joseph Anton*. The acclaimed 2012 memoir was titled for the alias Rushdie used during the 10 years he spent underground after the fundamentalist leader of Iran put a $3 million bounty on his head over a few passages of his 1988 novel *The Satanic Verses*. But if Rushdie is less than delighted with how the fatwa has defined much of his life,

he's game enough about acknowledging the surge in public interest when, 34 years later, it nearly ended it.

TIME: Not a pleasantry: how are you?

Salman Rushdie: I'm, you know, I'm getting there. The human body has a remarkable capacity for healing. I wouldn't say I'm 100% back, but I'm on the way.

Do you have a notion of what recovery will look like?

It'll look pretty much like this. And that's to say, the eye is not coming back. The eye is lost. The hand that was badly damaged is recovering quite well with a lot of therapy. And the other wounds are getting better. There's a lot of therapy that's needed. Obviously, there was a quite a lot of PTSD. But I'm getting better.

Can I ask about the PTSD therapy, if particular approaches were useful for you?

I have a very good therapist who I've had for quite a long time and who knows me very well. You just have to talk through the obvious stuff—nightmares, all that kind of thing—and it'll take the time it takes. As you can imagine, it's a very terrible event in a life. And it takes some digesting.

But one of the things I am doing is finding a way to write about what happened. Whatever is published next is very likely to be a text about that. For me, that's a way of kind of taking charge of it. I'm still working out exactly how it might go. I can't say a lot about it, except that it's my intention to do it and I'm working on it.

Read More: *Salman Rushdie Is on the 2023 TIME100 List*

My experience with reporting is that the closer you are to a violent event, the less coherent it is in the writing.

Mmhmm. True. I was extremely close to it.

Maybe that's for journalists. A friend of mine did a book about spending a long time with soldiers and was eventually bombed by an IED. And what he wrote about that was extraordinary.

I was a very good friend of Michael Herr, who wrote *Dispatches* about Vietnam. Of course, he was in the thick of it for a long period of time, and the book is extraordinary by consequence. He came out of it with quite a lot of damage, and it took him a long time to get over, if indeed he ever did. I'm not sure he ever did.

I don't imagine you're out in public much now?

Not a lot. I'm just taking very slow steps back into the world. I intend to reclaim my life as fully as I can, but slowly does it.

Could you see yourself getting on a stage again, being in a public setting?

That's the big question. And "I don't know" is the answer. Not anytime soon. One of the problems of what happened at Chautauqua is that there was no security at all. It wouldn't have required much in order to prevent what happened, but that there was none at all made possible what happened. [A deputy and a state trooper were somewhere at Rushdie's talk, but witnesses said Matar reached the stage unchallenged. During the attack he was

tackled by the moderator, Henry Reese, who was cut above his right eye. The trooper handcuffed the suspect. The Chautauqua Institution did not respond to a message requesting comment.]

If you're a novelist, you don't meet your audience that often. You sit in a room for a few years, and then every so often you come out of your room and meet your readers. I've always really enjoyed that moment of meeting people who care about your work. It would be a loss to never do it again. But we have to really think seriously about how.

I have to ask you about Iran. You must be following events there.

I went to Iran when I graduated from Cambridge, which was 1968, so it was a long time before the current administration. I really liked it. I thought it was a beautiful country, and I liked the people who I thought were very sophisticated and cultured and welcoming.

Now, I'm a little sick of the subject, because, frankly, my only connection with Iran is that they tried to kill me. I wish it weren't true. I mean, yes, I've been following events. I don't have a whole lot to say about it, except obvious things. I admire the young women of Iran and the men who are supporting them. But that's about it.

It occurs to me that you may well outlive the Islamic Republic.

Well, that'd be nice.

I used to work in Israel, where former Prime Minister Ehud Barak once answered a question

about terror by observing that Islam was a relatively young religion, “and there’s a great deal of energy there.”

The truth is, because of what happened around *The Satanic Verses*, people often associate me with religion and with writing about it. But actually, it’s more or less the opposite of what I am as a writer. I’m, myself, not a religious person; it’s never really been a major subject of my work with the exception of the passages in *The Satanic Verses*. One of the biggest damages that the attack on *The Satanic Verses* did was it misled people about the kind of writer that was being talked about. One of the things that people who read *The Satanic Verses*—which very few of its attackers did—notice, first of all, is that it’s funny. The number of letters I’ve had which go, “Who knew it was funny?” And the answer is, people who read it knew was funny.

They made people think of me as being in some way involved in arcane, theological battles. I’ve had to fight back to clear away those misapprehensions about my work. By now it’s OK, because that was my my fifth published book, and *Victory City*, which just came out, is my 21st. Three quarters of my life as a writer has happened since those days.

Are you promoting *Victory City*? And how are you going about it?

Not really. Because of what happened, what would have normally been quite an extensive book tour became nothing. I did one interview with with the *New Yorker*. And the book seems to be doing very well, so maybe it didn’t need me.

In your portrait for that New Yorker story, you look like an avatar for free expression.

I have this old-fashioned view that I'm mainly a novelist. I've done my share of fighting for free expression. For example, I'm very proud of my association with PEN America and the work we've done together. One of my things of greatest pride is to have co-founded the PEN World Voices Festival, which in its origin really was a way of introducing American readers to the rest of the world, to make the literary experience of Americans less parochial, perhaps. And it's succeeded beyond our wildest dreams.

You're back at work. Take me through your day.

Well, if I wasn't talking to you, I'd be probably trying to do a bit of writing. I've never been an early morning person, so I tend to work something like an office day. Maybe the exception is that I always, always, at night before going to bed, read what I wrote that day. For two reasons: one is to have it in my head the next morning, and the other is to see if there's things that need fixing after a few hours of being away from it. You know Hemingway had this thing he used to say: you should always write one sentence less than you know, so that in the morning, you know what the first sentence is. Because once you have the first sentence it's much easier to write the second sentence.

One thing to love about *Victory City* is that, as a fictional account of an invented empire, it exists in counterpoint to the attack.

It was finished before the attack.

Yes, but it's a work *about* imagination.

Yes. I was really, really fortunate that I had just finished work on it. I mean literally a week or so before the attack, I had finished correcting the galleys. So there was actually nothing further to do except publish it. And I know that if I'd been at another stage, if I'd been in the middle of it, it would have been very hard to finish it. Because actually, for quite a long time after the attack, writing was something which I couldn't do. Just wasn't available to me.

You were trying, or …?

I would try, but there was just nothing there. And in the end I didn't try. That seems to be coming back. Like the rest of me.

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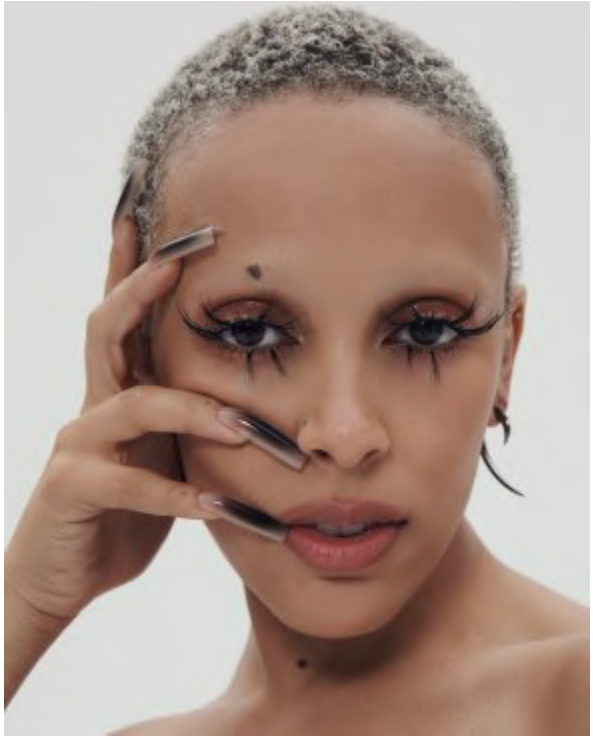
How Doja Cat Ripped Off Her Shell—And Why She's Happier For It

Belinda Luscombe is an editor at large at TIME, where she has covered a wide swath of topics, but specializes in interviews, profiles, and essays. In 2010, she won the Council on Contemporary Families Media Award for her stories on the ways marriage is changing. She is also author of *Marriageology: the Art and Science of Staying Together*.



Doja Cat is a creature born, bred, raised, and elevated by social media. The internet is her playground, her teacher, her inspiration, her disciplinarian, her delight, and her punishment. In person, Amala Ratna Zandile Dlamini, 27, is polite and cautious, and tends to look off to the side while formulating answers to questions. But on social media, she's Doja Cat—and she has claws. "I feel like we're all enjoying that argument on Twitter, the mess that comes with rude comments and stuff like that," she says in an interview after her TIME100 cover shoot, which she conducts without

cleaning off the lipstick smears on her face from the final few frames. “I like to dive into it. It’s part of who I am.”

Doja rose to prominence in 2019 after she went viral with “Moo,” a playful, lo-fi music video of her dressed (more or less) as a cow singing and rapping with a generous use “moo” puns. In the handful of years since, she has released two platinum-selling albums; won a slew of awards, including a Grammy and three VMAs; and become one of the 50 most streamed artists on Spotify. She has also become so avidly watched that even her recent breast-reduction-recovery updates—mostly provided via her social media feeds—made headlines.

“I grew up on the internet, constantly available to people, and I put myself there,” says Doja. “I’ve kind of become addicted to it. I think a lot of us are, but it’s become part of my career.” She understood early that music is now a visual medium almost as much as an auditory one, and her constant reinvention of her look, and ever more unorthodox use of makeup have been perhaps the most vital part of her artistic expression. At the Schiaparelli Haute Couture show in Paris in January, her head and torso were covered in red body paint and bedazzled with crystals, rendering her (almost) anonymous.

Thousands of performing artists have social media streams to interact with their fans, but few are as personally involved with them as Doja Cat. “I enjoy it,” she says. “Actually I deeper than enjoy it.” She uploads things others won’t: close-up shots of the multiple pimples on her forehead, random vulgar words with no context, a pre-sneeze snapshot. After a commenter told her she was setting a bad example by having cosmetic surgery at such a young age, she told them they could “eat my long quiet and warm farts“—not usually the type of response favored by those with professionals in charge of their PR. Days after the fashion show, she responded to critics disappointed that her all-red crystal look

didn’t include eyelashes by donning an eyelash mustache and goatee.

“I am very impulsive. And I see it as a form of entertainment for the people that are reading it and watching it. And I’m also entertained,” Doja says. “Social media has been a really big part of what I do. I’m just learning to control how much I put out, and the way that I put those things out.” And how is she mastering it? “Messing up. Making a big mistake, like just getting lit and going on [Instagram] Live and then seeing it the next day,” she says. “That’s kind of helped me step back, which is nice. It doesn’t feel good at first, but it’s helped a lot. I don’t know how else I would have done that.”

Social media may be her weakness, but Doja also cites it as the chief source of her inspiration. “I am kind of a recluse. I like to stay at home a lot,” she says. “I get a lot of my inspiration from Instagram, and different artists on Instagram.” She first developed her music on SoundCloud, dropping out of high school at 16, sitting under a blanket on a mattress on the floor, recording raps over beats she found there and uploading them for a tight circle of listeners. “I had my own little group of fans that I cherished and I kept close,” she says. “I was on live every day making music with them. And then it just kind of blew up over a meme.”

From the ages of about 8 to 12, Doja lived on a Californian ashram headed by Alice Coltrane, the wife of jazz musician John Coltrane, after Doja’s artist mother moved there from her grandmother’s house in Rye, N.Y. (Her father, who has not been a big part of her life, is South African actor and dancer Dumisani Dlamini.) While there, she learned her first dance moves from the Bharatanatyam tradition. While she doesn’t dance that way anymore, “I think that helped shape how I emote on stage because it’s a very emotional form of dance,” she says.

The ashram's strict routines, including head-covering, didn't sit well with a tween as expressive and spontaneous as Doja, so her family left and moved to suburban Tarzana. But in some ways, she is returning to some of the simplicity of that life, including cutting down on her appearances and shaving her head (on Instagram Live, obviously) last year. "I just realized that hair wasn't for me, unless it was a wig," she says. "When I shaved my head, it just gave me this sense of self that was different from any other time in my life. I almost feel like 10 to 15 years younger. I feel like I'm just pushing myself out there and just accepting myself for who I am, no matter who can see me. It's kind of like I ripped off my shell. I feel a lot happier."

If Doja can maintain the delicate balance with the push-pull of social media, fame, and influence, she has a lot of other spheres she'd like to conquer; she wants to act, design clothes and furniture, and even try stand-up. (Her favorite comic is Dave Chappelle.) In the immediate future, however, she's planning a new album, possibly called *Hellmouth*, a name she tested out on social media but is not sure will stick. She's also teasing fans about what genre it is. "I might just mess with everybody and completely turn the tables on them," she says. "But I like the idea of *Hellmouth* because it sounds good. And it's provocative." In other words, it's quite a lot like her.

Buy a print of the TIME100 Doja Cat cover here.

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